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ARCHITECTING ERP IN THE AGE OF AI

Which skills still matter — and which new ones must we build?

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OUR JOURNEY SO FAR

Three years, one through-line: what does a great Solution Architect actually do?

2023

V2.0

The Holistic View

We introduced the Wheel — Technical, Functional, Industry, Method, Commercial, Engagement. Six spokes that define the role.

2024

V3.0

Azure Synergy

We layered the Wheel into the broader Microsoft stack — integration, OneLake, BI, and the multi-instance reality.

2026

V4.0

The AI Era

The Wheel still holds. The contents inside every spoke are being rewritten by AI. Today we explore how.



SESSION AGENDA

45 minutes | Q&A at the end



01

Pop-Up Quiz

Where the room sits on the AI adoption curve

02

The Wheel Holds, the Contents Don't

Same six spokes — what's inside each one has changed

03

Three Spotlights

Technical, Functional, Method — what AI looks like up close

04

Where Architects Add Value Now

Feedback, tailoring, translation, visualization

05

Microsoft's Part & a Framework

Implementation agents, plus 5 gates to use AI safely

06

Roadmap, Take-Aways & Q&A

Your next 90 / 180 / 365 days — and your questions

POP-UP QUIZ

A quick read of the room before we begin.

1

What is your role on D365 implementations?

2

How often do you use AI tools in your daily work?

3

Has AI changed how you gather requirements?

4

Have you written a prompt as part of a design decision?

5

Do your clients ask about AI governance?

6

Is "AI literacy" on your team's development plan?

Scan the QR code on screen to submit your answers anonymously — results appear live.



THE NEW REALITY

In 12 months AI moved from a demo to a working tool on every implementation we touch.

∞

Copilots

across F&O, BC, Power Platform, Azure,
Microsoft 365 — all production-grade now

3×

Faster drafts

requirements, FDDs, configuration notes —
but quality is now the bottleneck

100%

Of clients

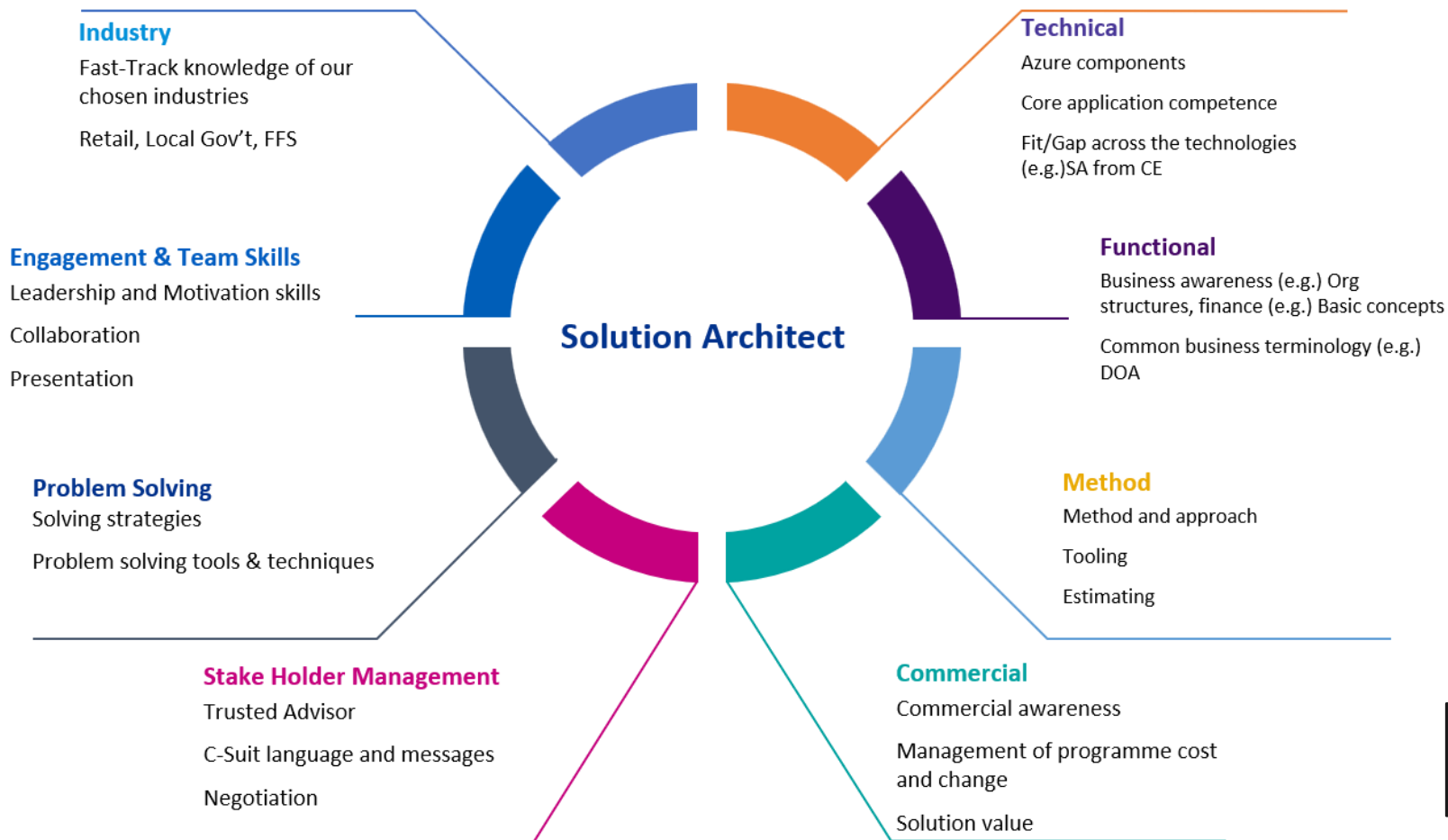
have an AI question on the table before the
contract is signed

The question is no longer "should we use AI?" — it is "where, how, and who is accountable?"



THE WHEEL HOLDS — THE CONTENTS DON'T

Same eight spokes. Every one of them is being filled with new tools, new tradeoffs, new craft.



SAME FRAMEWORK

The Wheel from V2.0 is unchanged. All six spokes still required for a great Solution Architect.

NEW CONTENTS

What lives INSIDE each spoke — the tools, the language, the daily craft — is being rewritten by AI.

THE QUESTION

Not "do we drop spokes?" — but "what does each spoke now demand?"

Next: OLD vs NEW across all six spokes.

OLD vs NEW — ALL SIX SPOKES

The spoke name is the same. The componentry inside it has changed.

SPOKE	OLD CONTENT	NEW CONTENT
TECHNICAL	Hand-built integrations, manual code, deep manuals.	GitHub Copilot, Copilot Studio, Azure AI Foundry.
FUNCTIONAL	Manual fit-gap, BPM authoring, feature-by-feature design.	Vibe coding, 1st/3rd-party productivity & delivery agents.
INDUSTRY	Domain experts holding context in their head.	Vertical AI models, industry copilots, accelerator data.
METHOD	Phase gates with hand-crafted documents at each step.	Same outputs — radically different journey through phases.
COMMERCIAL	Classic SOWs, T&M, value cases written by hand.	AI value cases, outcome-based pricing, agent ROI models.
ENGAGEMENT	Workshops then slow synthesis into deliverables.	Real-time co-creation; transcripts become first drafts.



We'll zoom into three of these next: Technical, Functional, and Method.

TECHNICAL — STACK STAYS, BUILD CHANGES

The architect still owns the stack — but the daily craft of building on it is unrecognisable.

YOUR EXAMPLE

Pair-programmer for X++, AL, PowerFx, C#, KQL.

GitHub Copilot

- First-draft code, refactors, and tests in seconds.
- Architect spends more time reviewing intent, less time typing.
- Trivial bugs caught earlier; harder ones still need you.

COMPLEMENTARY

Custom copilots and AI services grounded in your D365 data.

Copilot Studio + Azure AI Foundry

- Build copilots over F&O / BC data with retrieval grounding.
- Azure AI services for classification, summarisation, OCR, search.
- New architect skill: choosing where intelligence belongs in the stack.

FUNCTIONAL — FIT-GAP MEETS VIBE CODING

From hand-written features to spoken intent and agents that act on it.

YOUR EXAMPLE

Describe the change in plain English. See it scaffolded. Iterate fast.

Vibe Coding

- First-draft forms, flows, and configurations from a short prompt.
- Speed unlocks more options explored before commitment.
- Functional consultants need new vocabulary, not new degrees.

COMPLEMENTARY

First-party productivity agents + third-party delivery agents.

Agents — 1P & 3P

- Microsoft 365 / Sales / Service Copilots for end-user productivity.
- Power Platform & ISV agents for delivery, test, and operations.
- Microsoft Implementation Agent Templates — covered later in this deck.



Functional skill is now: pick the right agent, give it the right job, keep it on the rails.



METHOD — SAME OUTPUTS, DIFFERENT JOURNEY

The gates and deliverables don't move. The path between them is unrecognisable.

YOUR EXAMPLE

BPMs, FDDs, configuration notes, test scripts, cutover plans. All still required.

Same Outputs

- Quality bar for sign-off is unchanged — arguably higher.
- Audit trail, traceability, and intent must still hold up.
- Clients still want to see the same artefacts at the same gates.

COMPLEMENTARY

Hours replace weeks; transcripts replace memos.

New Journey

- Workshops → transcripts → first-draft user stories & FDDs.
- Continuous co-creation in tools, not async doc swaps.
- ALM, testing, and release cadence speed up — pressure-tests governance.

DOUBLE DOWN ON THESE

The skills AI does NOT replace — and that matter more, not less, in the AI era.

01

Business Knowledge

AI does not know your client's P&L, their auditors, their year-end. You do. Domain depth is the moat.

02

Stakeholder Management

Steering committees do not want a model — they want a person they trust. Earning that trust is still entirely human work.

03

Systems Thinking

AI is excellent at the next step. Architects are responsible for the whole. End-to-end thinking across modules, integrations, and time.

04

Judgement on Trade-Offs

Cost vs. complexity, in-app vs. extension, standard vs. customisation. AI surfaces options; the architect chooses.



WHERE THE ARCHITECT **NOW ADDS VALUE**

AI does the typing. You do the thinking, tailoring, translating — and showing.

FEEDBACK

Reviewing, challenging, and curating AI output before it touches the client. The first reader, not the first writer.

TAILORING

Adapting generic AI output to a specific industry, client, and team. The model knows ERP — you know THIS ERP.

TRANSLATION

Explaining the decision in the language the CFO, the CIO, and the end user each need to hear.

VISUALIZATION

Showing — not just telling — what the solution will look like. As we go faster, clients must SEE it to absorb it.



WHAT THE ARCHITECT **STILL OWNS**

The role does not shrink. It sharpens. These four things stay yours — by name.

1

DECISIONS

Trade-offs across cost, complexity, and risk. AI lays out options. You decide which one ships.

2

ACCOUNTABILITY

Sign-off, audit trail, and what reaches production. AI does not get called at 2am. You do.

3

INTENT

The "why this, not that" behind every design. Models optimise; architects choose what to optimise for.

4

TRUST

The relationship with the client and the team. Steering committees buy people, not models.



AI proposes. The architect disposes — and signs.

THE SPEED PROBLEM

We can now design faster than clients can absorb. That is a new risk — and a new job.

THE GAP

DAYS

to design.

WEEKS

to align, approve, and adopt.

Adoption — not build — is the new bottleneck.

THE ARCHITECT'S NEW JOB

Pace the client, not just the team.



Show, don't send

Walk through configs and screens live. A 30-min demo beats a 30-page doc.



Visualise decisions

Diagrams, swim-lanes, before/after screens — the architect's new deliverables.



Stage the absorption

Break big designs into client-sized chunks. Sign-off in slices, not in bricks.



Coach the change

AI accelerates build. The change team needs the architect at the table earlier.

 ***As we go faster, the architect's ability to EXPLAIN and SHOW becomes the limiting factor.***

SPEED vs. QUALITY & TRUST

AI accelerates delivery. The architect is now the brake — and the conscience.

WHAT AI GIVES YOU

SPEED

- First-draft FDDs in minutes, not days
- Auto-generated test scripts and data
- Configuration diffs across environments
- Faster onboarding of new consultants
- Real-time meeting summaries and action items

WHAT YOU MUST PROTECT

QUALITY & TRUST

- Hallucinations in design docs and configs
- Drift between AI draft and client intent
- Over-confidence — "the AI said so"
- Lost institutional memory if no one reviews
- Client relationships built on you, not the tool



SOFT SKILLS — DEAD OR ESSENTIAL?

A common claim: "AI does the hard thinking — we just need prompt jockeys now." We disagree.

"The faster machines write, the more valuable it becomes to know what should be written, by whom, for whom, and why — and to SHOW it."

1

LISTENING

Hearing what is NOT being said in a steering committee — AI can't.

2

FRAMING

Turning ambiguous problems into the right question, before any model runs.

3

VISUALIZING

Showing decisions live so clients can absorb them at AI-era pace.

4

INFLUENCING

Bringing CFOs, CIOs, and end users to a shared decision under pressure.



A PRACTICAL FRAMEWORK

Five gates to integrate AI without losing quality, IP, or client trust.

STEP 1	STEP 2	STEP 3	STEP 4	STEP 5
INTENT What decision are we trying to support? Never "use AI for AI's sake".	GROUND Which authoritative data does the model see — client docs, configs, code?	GENERATE Use AI for the first draft, structured outputs, options exploration.	CHALLENGE Human review by a named architect. Trade-offs, risks, edge cases.	COMMIT Sign-off, audit trail, and rollback path before it touches the client.

Step 4 is non-negotiable. AI proposes — the architect disposes.



IMPLEMENTATION AGENT TEMPLATES

Microsoft is shipping the tooling for implementation teams. Cross-functional. Architect-grade.

Source: Microsoft Learn — D365 Guidance · Implementation Agent Templates Overview (updated Mar 2026)

PLANNING

Release Planner Helper Agent

Automated discovery, analysis, and work-item creation for D365 release waves.

FOR THE ARCHITECT

Architects: faster impact assessment of every wave; less manual ticket triage.

DIAGNOSTICS

Trace Parser Agent

Performance trace analysis from hours to minutes via conversational AI.

FOR THE ARCHITECT

Architects: faster root-cause on production incidents; better post-mortems.

What we should expect — and ask for

More agents across the lifecycle (design, test, cutover, hypercare). Open templates we can extend. A clear line between Microsoft's job (platform) and ours (judgement).



YOUR ROADMAP

Where to invest your next 90, 180, and 365 days.

Crawl

Get hands dirty

- Use Copilot for every FDD, BPM, and config note
- Try one MS Implementation Agent on a live workstream
- Build one internal prompt library you re-use

Walk

Get structured

- Run the 5-gate framework on one live workstream
- Define AI acceptance criteria with your QA lead
- Coach one consultant on prompt + judgement

Run

Lead the conversation

- Own the AI governance section of an SOW
- Speak publicly about an AI-enabled delivery
- Mentor two SAs into AI-era competence



KEY TAKE-AWAYS

Five sentences. Steal them, share them, argue with them.

- 1 The Wheel holds. All six spokes still define the Solution Architect.
- 2 The contents inside every spoke are being rewritten — GitHub Copilot, vibe coding, agents, new method journeys.
- 3 The architect's value shifts to feedback, tailoring, translation, and visualization — not typing.
- 4 Decisions, accountability, intent, and trust still belong to the architect — by name.
- 5 Microsoft is shipping the tooling. Our job is to use it with judgement and pace the clients absorbing it.





THANK YOU

Q & A

Let's argue about it.

DY
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